



A NEW STARTER'S WORKBOOK · V1.0

Welcome to Claude.

A friendly, do-it-with-me walkthrough for getting Claude properly set up at The Digital Maze. Install the app, write your Instructions for Claude, and stand up your first Cowork Project the way we did Emlyn's. About forty minutes from start to finish.

VERSION

1.0

FOR

TDM staff

TIME

40 minutes

FROM

Scott Clarke

01 Hello.

Claude is, in plain terms, a brilliant new colleague who happens to live inside your laptop. You can ask it to draft a client email, sense-check a campaign brief, or summarise a forty-page report and it will have a proper go at it within seconds. The trick is learning how to talk to it. That is what this little book is for.

By the end of this workbook

OUTCOME 01

Claude Desktop installed.

Downloaded, signed in with your TDM email, set up the right way.

OUTCOME 02

Your Instructions for Claude written.

A one-page profile telling Claude who you are. Used in every chat.

OUTCOME 03

First Cowork Project live.

One real Project set up properly, the same way we did Emlyn's.

OUTCOME 04

Five golden rules in your head.

Plus a tick-box list for your first week so you actually use it.

How to read this

In order, from page 1 to page 12. Skip nothing. Each page builds on the one before it. If you only have ten minutes today, read up to page 6 and come back later. If you have the full forty, do the lot in one sitting. Have your laptop open while you read. Most pages ask you to actually do something.

One reading rule

If something does not make sense, stop and ask Scott or your team lead. This workbook is meant to feel obvious. If a step feels muddled, that is a workbook problem, not a you problem.

02 What Claude does for us.

The best way to understand what Claude is for is to see what TDM staff already use it for day-to-day. Six honest examples. None of them are theoretical. Every team has someone doing this kind of work right now.

COMMS

Draft a client email in your voice.

Paste the latest call notes, ask Claude to draft the follow-up. Sounds like you, not like a robot.

STRATEGY

Sense-check a campaign brief.

Before you send a brief to a client, ask Claude what is unclear, what is missing, what would push back.

OPERATIONS

Summarise a 1-2-1 call into actions.

Drop the Otter transcript in. Get a clean summary, decisions, and owner-tagged actions in seconds.

REPORTING

Pull a QBR together from raw notes.

Throw your raw monthly notes at Claude. Ask for the QBR structure, the headlines, the asks.

VOICE

Build a tone-of-voice doc from sent emails.

Claude reads a hundred of your sent emails and produces a tone profile you can reuse across everything.

PITCHES

Sense-check a pitch deck story.

Paste the deck outline. Ask Claude where the argument is weak and what the client will push back on.

The rule of thumb

If you are about to spend more than fifteen minutes on something that involves writing, summarising, sense-checking, or structuring, try Claude first. Worst case you save ten minutes. Best case you save an hour.

03 The three modes.

Claude Desktop has three modes along the top of the window: **Chat**, **Cowork**, and **Code**. Knowing which one to reach for matters. Most TDM staff live in Chat. Cowork is for delegated work. Code is mostly for the dev team.

MODE 01

Chat.

the conversation

A normal back-and-forth. You ask, Claude answers. Quick questions, drafting, brainstorming, thinking out loud.

WHEN TO USE

Most of your day-to-day. Email drafts, brief sense-checks, summaries, anything you would normally type into ChatGPT.

MODE 02

Cowork.

the delegator

Multi-step jobs that touch your tools (Gmail, Drive, Slack, Calendar). Less ask-and-answer, more "go and do this for me".

WHEN TO USE

Recurring workflows. Pulling reports from Drive, drafting from emails, monthly board prep, anything you do repeatedly.

MODE 03

Code.

the developer's tool

For building and editing software. Claude reads, writes and edits files in a project folder on your machine.

WHEN TO USE

Mostly the dev team (Liam, Aaron, Calum, Oakley). If you are not building software, you can ignore this one.

For TDM staff: Chat and Cowork

If you are in SEO, PPC, Projects, Client Services, Sales or Marketing, you will live in Chat and dip into Cowork for the repetitive work. We will set up both in the next few pages.

01 Install Claude Desktop.

First job. Get the app on your machine and signed in. Five minutes. The rest of the workbook assumes you have Claude Desktop open in front of you.

A. Download and install

- 01 Open your web browser and go to **claude.ai/download**.
- 02 Click the button for your computer. Mac or Windows. The installer will download.
- 03 Open the installer and follow the prompts. Same as installing any other app.

B. Sign in

- 01 Open **Claude Desktop**. Click **Sign in**.
- 02 Use your TDM email address: *yourname@thedigitalmaze.com*. Claude will email you a code to confirm.
- 03 If you are asked which plan to choose, stop. Ask **Scott** or **Liam**. Your seat is on the TDM Team plan and they will sort it.

C. Find your way around

- 01 Look at the top of the window. You should see three tabs: **Chat**, **Cowork**, **Code**. Stay on **Chat** for now.
- 02 Bottom-left of the window, you will see your name. Click it. This is where **Settings** live. We will come back here on the next page.

If something does not work

Ask **Liam**. Sign-in problems, plan issues, anything technical. Faster than wrestling with it on your own.

02 Your Instructions for Claude.

This is the bit that makes Claude actually useful. You write a one-page profile that tells Claude who you are and how you like to work. Claude reads it at the start of every chat. You only do this once. About twenty-five minutes.

> Full prompt on the site: setting-up-claude-properly.vercel.app/bootstrap

Two files, two homes

Your profile splits into two files. **CLAUDE.md** holds the permanent stuff (your role, your style, your rules).

Context.md holds the changing stuff (this quarter's priorities). If it will still be true in six months, it goes in CLAUDE.md.

A. Let an AI write it for you

- 01 Open ChatGPT, Gemini, or whichever AI you have used most. Make sure **Memory** is turned on in its settings so it knows things about you.
- 02 Start a fresh chat. Paste the "**Interview Me and Write My CLAUDE.md**" prompt from the site. Edit the "Who I am" section so it matches you.
- 03 Answer the questions one at a time. Be specific. It will produce your CLAUDE.md as a code block.
- 04 Ask the AI to split that file into **CLAUDE.md** (permanent) and **Context.md** (changing). You will get two code blocks.

B. Paste your CLAUDE.md into Claude Desktop

- 01 In **Claude Desktop**, click your name (bottom-left) → **Settings** → **Profile**.
- 02 Find the box labelled **Instructions for Claude**. Paste your CLAUDE.md in. Click **Save**.
- 03 While you are there, toggle **Memory** on (same page). Lets Claude remember small things across chats.

C. Test it works

- 01 Start a brand-new chat. Type: *"What do you know about me and how I like to work?"*
- 02 If Claude plays back your role and preferences accurately, you are sorted. If it is vague, the file needs more detail.

Your **Context.md** gets a different home. You will drop it into a Cowork Project on page 8.

03 Your first Chat.

Now you have Claude installed and your profile in place, let us actually use it. The point of this page is to feel Claude actually working before you do anything more involved. Five minutes.

A. Open a fresh chat

- 01 In **Claude Desktop**, click the **Chat** tab at the top.
- 02 Click **New chat** (or the + icon, depending on your version). You should see an empty chat box.

B. Try this first message

Paste the prompt below. It checks your Instructions for Claude are actually loaded and gives you a feel for how Claude responds.

Prompt — First chat sanity check

[PASTE INTO CLAUDE CHAT](#)

Hi. Before we work on anything, do a quick sanity check for me.

STEP 1: Tell me what you know about me from my Instructions for Claude. Cover my role, the kind of work I do, and any preferences I have shared with you.

STEP 2: Tell me one realistic thing you could help me with this week, based on what you know.

Be specific. If anything in my profile is unclear or contradictory, flag it.

C. What "working" looks like

- 01 Claude should play back your role and the kind of work you do. If it is vague, your CLAUDE.md needs more detail. Go back to page 6.
- 02 Claude should suggest something realistic to your week. If the suggestion feels generic, that is also a clue your profile is too thin.
- 03 Reply to the suggestion. Have a proper back-and-forth for a few minutes. Get used to the rhythm of asking, reviewing, refining.

You are now using Claude

That is the whole point. From here on, the only difference is the type of work you give it. The next pages set up **Cowork**, which is where you delegate the bigger, repetitive jobs.

04 Your first Cowork Project.

Cowork is where you let Claude take on real, multi-step work that touches your tools (email, Drive, Slack, calendar). The first project always feels like the trickiest one, so we will do it together. Let Claude do the writing. You just answer a few quick questions.

> Full walkthrough on the site: setting-up-claude-properly.vercel.app/setup-cowork

A. Open Cowork and get the basics right

- 01 Open **Claude Desktop** and sign in. At the top of the window, click the **Cowork** tab.
- 02 Bottom-right of the chat input, click the model selector and pick **Sonnet**. Cheaper, plenty good for day-to-day.
- 03 Left sidebar → **Customize** → turn on the connectors you actually use: **Gmail**, **Google Drive**, **Slack**, **Google Calendar**.

B. Build your reusable template

- 01 Open **Finder**, go to **Documents**, and create a folder called **cowork-projects**. Inside it, create another folder called **_template**.
- 02 Switch back to Claude Desktop and click the **Chat** tab. Start a new chat. Paste the prompt below. Answer Claude's questions briefly. You will get three template files back.

Prompt 1 — Build my Cowork template

PASTE INTO CLAUDE CHAT

I'm setting up Cowork to help me with recurring work. Each piece of recurring work will get its own Cowork Project, and I need a reusable template I can copy whenever I start a new one.

Please do this in two steps.

STEP 1: Ask me 4 or 5 quick questions about how I work, one at a time. Cover what kind of work I do, what recurring things I want to use Cowork for, what tools I use, and how I communicate with people. Wait for my answer after each question.

STEP 2: Produce three blank template markdown files: PROJECT.md, CONTEXT.md, CURRENT-STATE.md. Each in a separate code block.

Start with the first question.

04 Save, fill, and load it in.

Now you have three template files in Claude Chat. Time to save them to your Mac, fill them in for a specific piece of work, and load that work into a real Cowork Project.

C. Save the three template files

- 01 Open **TextEdit** (press Cmd+Space, type TextEdit, hit Enter). Click **Format** → **Make Plain Text**. Important.
- 02 In Claude, click inside the first code block. Cmd+A to select all, Cmd+C to copy. Switch to TextEdit, Cmd+V to paste, Cmd+S to save.
- 03 Name it exactly **PROJECT.md**. Save it into your **_template** folder. If asked about file extension, choose **Use .md**.
- 04 Repeat for **CONTEXT.md** and **CURRENT-STATE.md**. Same folder.

D. Create your first real project folder

- 01 In Finder, go to **cowork-projects**. Right-click **_template** → **Duplicate**.
- 02 Rename the copy to your first project (lowercase, hyphens, no spaces). For Emlyn this was **monthly-ppc-review**. Pick one piece of recurring work you actually do.

E. Get Claude to fill in the files

- 01 Back in Claude Chat, start a new chat. Paste the prompt below. Replace **[PROJECT NAME]** with the name of your project.

F. Load it into Cowork

- 01 Save the three files into your new project folder (same TextEdit method as Step C).
- 02 In Claude Desktop, switch to **Cowork**. Left sidebar → **Projects** → **New Project**. Name it the same as the folder.
- 03 Find the **Project Knowledge** area. Drag all three .md files in. Paste **PROJECT.md** into the **Custom Instructions** box. Save.

Your first Project is live

Open it. Start a new task inside it. Ask: "What do you know about this project?" If Claude plays back your files accurately, you are sorted. Use this Project for a couple of weeks before adding another.

05 What TDM has set up for you.

You are not on your own. TDM has Claude organised in three layers, so when you sit down to work Claude already knows the company, your team, and you. Here is what is already in place and who keeps it up to date.

LAYER 01

Your account.

The paid Claude seat. Owned by TDM, billed centrally by Rob. Suspended the day you leave. Includes Chat and Cowork. Code is added for the dev team.

LAYER 02

Your team.

A shared library of skills, connectors, and reference docs specific to your team (SEO, PPC, Projects, Tech, etc.). Maintained by your team lead. Pulled when you start a session.

LAYER 03

You.

Your CLAUDE.md, Context.md, your tone of voice, your Cowork Projects. Lives on your Mac. Yours. Set up across pages 6 and 8 of this workbook.

Connectors you already have

Each connector lets Cowork reach into a tool you already use. Turn on the ones you actually use, not everything. Each one adds context to every Cowork task.

EVERYONE

Gmail • Drive • Slack • Calendar

The core four. Turn these on first. They cover most day-to-day work across every team.

SEO & PPC

GA4 • Search Console • SEMrush

Available on request. Ask Liam to enable them on your account if your team uses them.

PROJECTS & CS

Monday • Trello • MarketingIQ

If your team coordinates in one of these, add it. Cowork can read tasks and update boards.

If something is missing

The Layer 02 skills and connectors are still being rolled out team by team (SEO first). If your team has not had its kit set up yet, ask **Scott**. You can still use Chat and your personal Cowork Projects in the meantime.

06 Five rules & your first week.

Five rules to keep in your head from day one, then a tick-box list for your first week so the workbook does not just sit on your desk.

| The five golden rules

01 Be specific.

Vague in, vague out. "Write me an email" gets you nothing. "Draft a friendly reply to Acme rejecting their counter-offer but keeping the door open" gets you something usable.

02 Tell Claude your role and audience.

"I am a PPC account manager writing to a non-technical client" changes the whole reply. Your Instructions for Claude already cover most of this. Top it up per task.

03 Ask Claude to ask you questions first.

Before you brief Claude on a big task, tell it: "Before you do this, ask me 3 questions you need answered to do it well." Catches missing info early.

04 Review before you approve.

Especially in Cowork, when Claude is about to send an email, post in Slack, or update a board. Read every action before you confirm it. No exceptions.

05 Never paste passwords or proper secrets.

Client logins, payment details, API keys, anything sensitive. Claude does not need them and TDM does not want them in a chat history.

| Your first-week tick-box

- ☐ Profile set up. **Instructions for Claude** filled in. Memory toggled on.
- ☐ First real Chat done. Got Claude to play back what it knows about you.
- ☐ One Cowork Project created. Tested. Used for at least one real task.
- ☐ Tried Chat AND Cowork. Both have a place in your week.
- ☐ Read the **Talking to Claude** page on the site.
- ☐ Pulled an existing task into Claude. Saved at least twenty minutes.

07 Where to go next.

You have done the foundation. The site is where you go deeper when you want to. It has prompts, a glossary, deep-dives on connectors, a troubleshooting page, and recommended tools by team.

THE FULL GUIDE LIVES HERE

setting-up-claude-properly

Twenty-five sections. Searchable. Updated regularly. Save it to your bookmarks bar.

[.vercel.app](https://vercel.app)

Read these next

ALL MODES

Talking to Claude.

How to get the best out of any chat. Specifics over generalities, examples, structure.

ALL MODES

Reviewing Work.

How to check what Claude has done, especially in Cowork where actions touch real tools.

ALL MODES

Common Mistakes.

The handful of patterns that consistently waste time. Read it before you make them.

ALL MODES

Security.

What never to share, where things get stored, what to do if you slip up.

Who to ask at TDM

Scott Clarke

Anything Claude, the workbook itself, where to find things, what skills are coming for your team.

Liam Nelson

Anything technical. Sign-in problems, connector issues, MCP setups, plan and seat questions.

Your team lead

Team-specific workflows, the skills already built for your team, who else on the team is using what.